# The instability of negative-mass Schwarzschild is a point-mass effect:

Exact thresholds for finite stars

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**Abstract**

Negative-mass Schwarzschild spacetime is linearly unstable: Gleiser and Dotti exhibited, for every multipole $\ell \geq 2$, an even-parity mode growing as $e^{\gamma t}$ with $\gamma = (\ell-1)\ell(\ell+1)(\ell+2)/(12|M|)$, and gave numerical evidence that it is the only one. It has been suggested that the instability does not depend on the singularity and would survive in a regular negative-mass star. We prove, for every $\ell \geq 2$, that the Dotti–Gleiser operator has exactly one negative eigenvalue. The proof uses the zero-energy partner solution $\phi_0 = 1/\psi_0$ implicit in their intertwining construction, through a ground-state identity and Glazman's lemma. The same identity yields an exact count of unstable modes for the exterior of a star of areal radius $R$ whose interior imposes a Robin condition $\hat{\Psi}' = \kappa\hat{\Psi}$: $\#\{\gamma > 0\} = [\, R < r_s \,] + [\, \kappa < \kappa_c(R) \,]$, with $r_s = 6|M|/[(\ell+2)(\ell-1)]$ and $\kappa_c$ in closed form. Consequently the vacuum exterior of any star with $R \geq r_*(\ell)$ ($r_* = 2.279|M|$ for $\ell = 2$) and a non-energy-injecting surface condition ($\kappa \geq 0$) supports no unstable even-parity mode, and the $\ell^4$ growth of the point mass is capped by any finite radius. A companion paper applies the count to a regular negative-mass boson star.

## 1 Introduction

Bondi's 1957 analysis [1] showed that general relativity contains no logical obstruction to negative mass, provided inertial, passive and active mass share a sign, and that a pair of equal and opposite masses self-accelerates (the "runaway"). Two questions have dominated the subsequent discussion: whether negative mass is dynamically stable, and whether the runaway is physical. The second was recently addressed by full $3+1$ evolutions of a canonical boson star paired with a "phantom" boson star of negative ADM mass [2]. Here we address the first.

For the vacuum point mass the answer is known. Gibbons, Hartnoll and Ishibashi [3] proved stability of the odd-parity sector and, for a range of boundary conditions at the naked singularity, of the even sector. Gleiser and Dotti [4] then found exact, smooth, exponentially growing even-parity solutions and showed that the stability argument of Ref. [3] relies on a perturbation that is not continuous at an interior radius where the Zerilli variable is singular. Dotti and Gleiser [5] removed that "kinematic" singularity with an intertwining operator, obtained a regular operator $\hat{H}$ with a unique self-adjoint extension, and showed that the unstable mode is excited by generic data supported away from the singularity. Cardoso and Cavaglià [6] identified the modes as algebraically special. Whether the unstable mode is the only one was left as numerical evidence [5].

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What a regular negative-mass source does to this instability has not been computed. In a recent review Dotti suggests that replacing the singularity by a small negative-mass distribution would leave the potential largely unchanged, so that "an unstable mode could be found anyway", and that "the singularity plays no role in the instability" [7]. Regular negative-mass configurations exist—perfect-fluid bubbles in de Sitter [8], scalar-field stars [2]—but stability analyses have been radial and restricted to special matter models [9, 10].

This paper makes two contributions.

1. We prove that $\hat{H}$ has exactly one negative eigenvalue for every $\ell \geq 2$ (Theorem 1), turning the numerical observation of Ref. [5] into a theorem.

2. For the exterior of a star of radius $R$ with a Robin interface condition, we give an exact count of unstable modes for every $\ell$ (Theorem 2). The instability is a property of the region $r \lesssim 10|M|/\ell^2$: a star larger than $r_*(\ell)$ hides it unless its surface condition injects energy, and any finite star caps the growth rate. This quantifies, and for dilute stars contradicts, the expectation of Ref. [7].

A companion paper [11] computes the surface condition a concrete regular negative-mass object—a phantom boson star—supplies, and finds it on the stable side of $\kappa_c$.

Units $G = c = 1$ and $|M| = 1$ throughout. All computations are reproducible from the accompanying repository.

## 2 The intertwined Zerilli operator

Write the negative-mass Schwarzschild metric as $\mathrm{d}s^2 = -f\mathrm{d}t^2 + f^{-1}\mathrm{d}r^2 + r^2\mathrm{d}\Omega^2$ with $f = 1 - 2M/r = 1 + 2/r$ ($M = -1$), and the tortoise coordinate $x = r - 2\ln(1 + r/2)$, so $x \in (0, \infty)$ with $x \simeq r^2/4$ at the singularity. Even-parity perturbations with multipole $\ell \geq 2$ reduce to Zerilli's equation [12] $\partial_t^2 \Psi_Z + H_Z \Psi_Z = 0$, $H_Z = -\partial_x^2 + V_Z$. Let

$$c = (\ell + 2)(\ell - 1), \qquad k = \frac{(\ell - 1)\ell(\ell + 1)(\ell + 2)}{6} = \frac{c(c + 2)}{6}, \qquad r_s = \frac{6}{c}. \tag{1}$$

For $M < 0$ the potential $V_Z$ has a double pole at $r_s$, which lies in the physical domain; it is "kinematic" because $\Psi_Z$ itself has a simple pole there for smooth metric perturbations [4].

Dotti and Gleiser [5] use the static solution $\psi_0 = \chi(r)/(cr - 6)$ of $H_Z \psi_0 = 0$, where $\chi$ is the polynomial of degree $\ell + 2$ in their Eq. (55), and define $g = \psi_0'/\psi_0$ ($' = \mathrm{d}/\mathrm{d}x$),

$$A = \partial_x + g, \qquad H_Z = AA^*, \qquad \hat{H} = A^*A = -\partial_x^2 + \hat{V}, \qquad \hat{V} = g^2 - g'. \tag{2}$$

$\hat{V}$ is regular, $\hat{H}A^* = A^*H_Z$, and $\hat{\Psi} = A^*\Psi_Z$ is smooth for smooth metric perturbations. The zero-energy partner of this factorisation,

$$\phi_0 = \frac{1}{\psi_0} = \frac{cr - 6}{\chi(r)}, \qquad A\phi_0 = 0, \qquad \hat{H}\phi_0 = 0, \tag{3}$$

appears in Ref. [5] as the state "missing in the spectrum" of the supersymmetric partner. It is the object on which everything below rests. Figure 1 shows $\hat{V}$: it is negative only on a thin shell just outside $r_s$, and when lengths are scaled by $c$ and energies by $k^2$ the shell is nearly independent of $\ell$.

**Lemma 1** (properties of $\chi$, $\phi_0$, $\hat{V}$; all $\ell \geq 2$)**.**

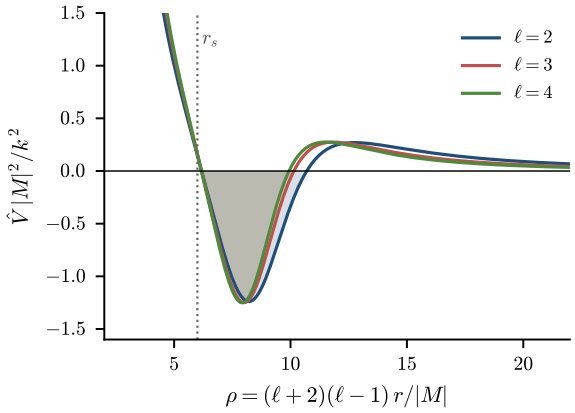



Figure 1: The regularised potential $\hat{V}$ for $\ell = 2, 3, 4$, in the scaled radius $\rho = cr/|M|$. Shaded: $\hat{V} < 0$, which occurs only on a shell just beyond $r_s$ ($\rho = 6$). With radius scaled by $c = (\ell+2)(\ell-1)$ and the potential by the eigenvalue scale $k^2$, the curves nearly coincide.

1. *$\chi = \sum_{n=1}^{\ell+2} c_n r^n$ with $c_1 = \frac{3}{2}$, $c_2 = 0$, $c_3 = -K/32$, $c_4 = K/96$ ($K = 6k$), $c_n \geq 0$ for $n \geq 4$ and $c_{\ell+2} > 0$; $\psi_0$ solves the static Zerilli equation identically in $\ell$; and $\chi > 0$ on $r > 0$.*

2. *At $r_s$ the $\chi$-equation has Frobenius exponents 0 and 3, forcing $\chi''(r_s) = 0$; hence $\hat{V}$ is real-analytic on $(0, \infty)$.*

3. *$r^4\hat{V} = 12 + O(r)$ as $r \to 0$ (exponents $x^{3/2}$, $x^{-1/2}$), and $\hat{V} \simeq (\ell+1)(\ell+2)/r^2$ as $r \to \infty$. $\hat{H}$ is limit point at both ends, hence essentially self-adjoint on $C_c^\infty(0, \infty)$.*

4. *$\phi_0$ is the non-admissible branch $\propto x^{-1/2}$ at 0, decays as $r^{-(\ell+1)}$ at infinity, and has exactly one zero, at $r_s$, which is simple.*

*Sketch.* (1) The closed form $c_n = (n-2)\big((n-4)\ell(\ell+1) + n - 1\big)(\ell - n + 3)_{2n-4}/\big(2^n(n-1)!^2\big)$ turns the static equation into a three-term recurrence, which becomes a polynomial identity in $(\ell, n)$ after dividing by a Pochhammer factor; it is verified symbolically. Positivity follows Ref. [5], Eqs. (57)–(59): dropping the non-negative terms $n \geq 6$ leaves a quartic whose unique positive critical value is $4(K-18)(Ks - 18(K-16))/[(\ell-2)(\ell+3)(\ell^2+\ell+4)]^3$, $s = \sqrt{6(K-18)}$, which is positive because $(Ks)^2 - (18(K-16))^2 = 6(K-24)^3 > 0$ for $\ell \geq 3$; $\ell = 2$ is checked directly. (2)–(4) are local expansions, verified symbolically in $\ell$; limit point at 0 holds because $x^{-1/2} \notin L^2$, and the Weyl alternative gives essential self-adjointness [13, 14]. □

## 3 Exactly one unstable mode

The key tool is the ground-state identity: if $\hat{V} = \phi_0''/\phi_0$ and $u = \phi_0 h$, then

$$u'^2 + \hat{V}u^2 = \phi_0^2 h'^2 + \big(\phi_0\phi_0' h^2\big)'. \tag{4}$$

**Theorem 1.** *For every $\ell \geq 2$, $\hat{H}$ has exactly one negative eigenvalue. It is simple and equals $-(k/2)^2$, so the unique unstable even-parity mode of negative-mass Schwarzschild grows at the Gleiser–Dotti rate $\gamma = k/(2|M|)$. Zero is not an eigenvalue.*

*Proof. At most one.* By Glazman's lemma [15], the number of negative eigenvalues equals the largest dimension of a subspace of a form core on which $q[u] = \langle u, \hat{H}u\rangle$ is negative definite. Take the core $C_c^\infty(0,\infty)$ and suppose such a subspace $F$ has $\dim F \geq 2$. Choose $u \in F \setminus \{0\}$ with $u(x_s) = 0$, $x_s = x(r_s)$. Since $\phi_0$ is analytic with a simple zero at $x_s$, $h = u/\phi_0$ is smooth, and integrating (4) over the compact support of $u$ gives $q[u] = \int \phi_0^2 h'^2 \,\mathrm{d}x \geq 0$, a contradiction.

*At least one.* The function $\hat{\Psi} = A^*\Psi_{\mathrm{DG}}$, with $\Psi_{\mathrm{DG}} = r(r+2)^k e^{-kr/2}/(cr-6)$, satisfies $\hat{H}\hat{\Psi} = -(k/2)^2\hat{\Psi}$ identically in $\ell$, is $O(r^3)$ at 0, regular at $r_s$, and decays exponentially; so it is an eigenfunction. Independently of this explicit mode, $w = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{x>x_s}$ lies in the form domain with $q[w] = 0$ by (4); if $\hat{H} \geq 0$, $w$ would be a minimiser and hence a weak, therefore $C^1$, solution of $\hat{H}w = 0$, contradicting the kink at $x_s$.

*No zero mode.* The zero-energy solution admissible at $x = 0$ is

$$v = \phi_0 F, \qquad F(r) = \text{f.p.}\int_0^r \psi_0^2 \,\frac{\mathrm{d}x}{\mathrm{d}r}\,\mathrm{d}r;$$

it grows as $r^{\ell+2}$ and is not in $L^2$. □

*Remark* 1. $v$ has exactly one zero for every $\ell$ ($F$ is positive on $(0, r_s)$ and increases from $-\infty$ to $+\infty$ on $(r_s, \infty)$), as renormalised oscillation theory [16] requires. The proof does not use oscillation theory at the continuum edge. Numerically, Chebyshev discretisations with $\hat{\Psi} = r^3 u$ reproduce $E_0 = -(k/2)^2$ to $\leq 3 \times 10^{-13}$ for $\ell \leq 8$ and find no second bound state in 140 resolution and domain variations.

## 4 Finite stars: an exact count

Model the exterior of a star of areal radius $R$ by $\hat{H}_{R,\kappa}$ on $L^2(x_R, \infty)$ with the Robin condition $\hat{\Psi}'(x_R) = \kappa\hat{\Psi}(x_R)$; $\kappa = +\infty$ denotes Dirichlet. The interior matter determines $\kappa$, which in general depends on frequency and $\ell$; here it is a free parameter. Define

$$\kappa_c(R) = \frac{\mathrm{d}\ln\phi_0}{\mathrm{d}x}\Big|_R = \Big(1 + \frac{2}{R}\Big)\frac{\mathcal{N}(R)}{(cR-6)\chi(R)}, \qquad \mathcal{N} = c\chi - (cr-6)\chi'. \tag{5}$$

**Theorem 2.** *For every $\ell \geq 2$ and $R \neq r_s$, the number of negative eigenvalues of $\hat{H}_{R,\kappa}$ is*

$$[\,R < r_s\,] + [\,\kappa < \kappa_c(R)\,], \tag{6}$$

*with Dirichlet counted as $\kappa = +\infty$. At $\kappa = \kappa_c$, $\phi_0$ is a zero-energy eigenfunction.*

*Proof.* For $u$ in the core, (4) gives $q[u] = \int \phi_0^2 h'^2 \,\mathrm{d}x + (\kappa - \kappa_c)u(x_R)^2$ provided $u(x_s) = 0$ when $R < r_s$. Imposing $u(x_s) = 0$ (if $R < r_s$) and $u(x_R) = 0$ (if $\kappa < \kappa_c$) costs at most $[\,R < r_s\,] + [\,\kappa < \kappa_c\,]$ linear conditions and leaves $q \geq 0$; Glazman's lemma gives the upper bound. For the lower bound use $w_1 = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{[x_R, x_s]}$ and $w_2 = \phi_0 \mathbf{1}_{[x_s,\infty)}$ (or $\phi_0$ itself if $R > r_s$), for which $q[aw_1 + bw_2] = a^2\phi_0(x_R)^2(\kappa - \kappa_c)$ and $q[w_2] = 0$. If the negative spectral subspace were smaller, some combination orthogonal to it would have $q = 0$, hence be a weak zero-energy solution satisfying the boundary condition; the kink of $w_2$, or $\kappa \neq \kappa_c$, excludes this. □

**Corollary 1** (thresholds, all $\ell$)**.** *$\mathcal{N} > 0$ on $[0, r_s]$ and has exactly one root $r_* > r_s$. Hence $\kappa_c < 0$ on $(0, r_s)$, $\kappa_c \to \mp\infty$ at $r_s^{\mp}$, $\kappa_c > 0$ on $(r_s, r_*)$ and $\kappa_c < 0$ on $(r_*, \infty)$. In particular: Dirichlet is unstable iff $R < r_s$; Neumann is unstable iff $R < r_*$; every $\kappa \geq 0$ is stable iff $R \geq r_*$.*

| $\ell$ | $r_s$ | $r_*$ | $r_{\rm neg}$ | $\gamma_{\rm DG} = k/2$ | $\lvert M\rvert/r_*$ |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| 2 | 1.5000 | 2.2788 | 2.6741 | 2 | 0.439 |
| 3 | 0.6000 | 0.8789 | 1.0143 | 10 | 1.14 |
| 4 | 0.3333 | 0.4814 | 0.5519 | 30 | 2.08 |
| 5 | 0.2143 | 0.3073 | 0.3512 | 70 | 3.25 |

Table 1: Thresholds in units of $|M|$. $r_s$: Dirichlet threshold; $r_*$: Neumann and $\kappa \geq 0$ threshold; $r_{\rm neg} = \sup\{r : \hat{V} < 0\}$. Since $r_*$ decreases with $\ell$ (checked for $\ell \leq 80$), a star with $|M|/R < 0.439$ and $\kappa \geq 0$ has no unstable even-parity mode for any $\ell$. At large $\ell$, $r_* \approx 8.486/c$ and $r_{\rm neg} \approx 9.636/c$ (derived from the $\ell \to \infty$ limit of $c\,\chi(\rho/c)$, a modified-Bessel closed form; convergence of the roots is not proven).

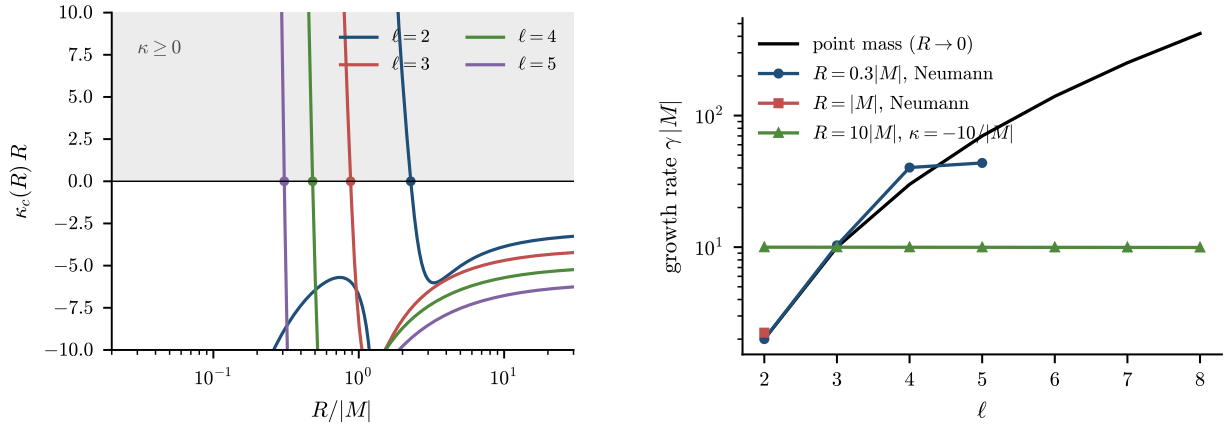



Figure 2: Left: critical surface condition $\kappa_c(R)R$ for $\ell = 2$–5. A mode is unstable when $\kappa < \kappa_c$, plus one unconditional mode when $R < r_s$ (pole). Dots mark $r_*$. Above $r_*$ the whole $\kappa \geq 0$ region (shaded) is stable. Right: growth rate versus $\ell$. The point mass grows as $\ell^4/12$; any finite $R$ with an $\ell$-independent condition leaves finitely many unstable $\ell$ ($\kappa \geq 0$) or caps the rate at $|\kappa|$ ($\kappa < 0$, since $\hat{V} \geq 0$ outside $r_{\rm neg}$).

The first claim follows from a telescoping lower bound on $[0, r_s]$; uniqueness of $r_*$ from Descartes' rule applied to $\mathcal{N}(r_s+t)$, whose coefficients have one sign change because $\chi''(r_s) = 0$ and $\chi^{(m)}(r_s) > 0$ for $m \geq 4$. Table 1 lists the thresholds and Fig. 2 the critical surface condition. Asymptotically,

$$\kappa_c = -\frac{\ell+1}{R} - \frac{\ell^4+3\ell^3+4\ell^2+4}{\ell(\ell-1)(\ell+2)}\frac{1}{R^2} + O(R^{-3}) \qquad (R \to \infty), \tag{7}$$

$$\kappa_c\, x_R = -\frac{1}{2} - \frac{(\ell^2+\ell-1)R}{12} + O(R^2) \qquad (R \to 0). \tag{8}$$

For large $R$ an instability therefore requires a surface condition softer than the static vacuum tail $\phi_0 \propto r^{-(\ell+1)}$ by an $O(1)$ factor on the scale $1/R$. As $R \to 0$ every condition with $\kappa x_R > -\frac{1}{2}$ (including Dirichlet and Neumann) reproduces the Dotti–Gleiser eigenvalue, with error scaling roughly as $R^3$–$R^4$, so the self-adjoint extension of Ref. [5] is the limit of a regular cutoff; compare the scalar-wave analysis of Ref. [17].

**Growth-rate cap.** For the point mass the growth rate $k/2 \sim \ell^4/12$ is unbounded in $\ell$. For a star: with $\kappa \geq 0$ only $\ell$ with $R < r_*(\ell)$, roughly $\ell \lesssim 3/\sqrt{R}$, are unstable; with a fixed $\kappa < 0$, every $\ell$ with $r_{\rm neg}(\ell) < R$ has $\hat{V} \geq 0$ outside the star and growth $\leq |\kappa|$. Either way $\sup_\ell \gamma < \infty$ (Fig. 2, right; a 1000-case numerical scan agrees with Theorem 2). The unbounded growth belongs to the singularity.

## 5 Discussion

For the point mass, Theorem 1 completes the linear stability analysis: negative-mass Schwarzschild has one unstable even-parity mode per $\ell$, at the Gleiser–Dotti rate, and no others. Theorem 2 shows where that mode lives. The negative part of the effective potential sits on a shell of radius $\approx 10|M|/\ell^2$ (Fig. 1); a star whose surface lies outside $r_*(\ell)$ hides it unless its interior supplies an energy-injecting surface condition, and for $\ell = 2$ the condition is $|M|/R < 0.439$. In this sense the instability is a point-mass effect, contrary to the suggestion in Ref. [7]: for a dilute regular source the vacuum exterior cannot drive it, and the $\ell^4$ growth disappears.

Which side of $\kappa_c$ a real star lies on is a property of its matter. For the phantom boson star of Ref. [2] the companion paper [11] finds $\kappa_{\rm eff} > \kappa_c$ for $\ell = 2$, together with the identity $\kappa_{\rm eff} - \kappa_c = s^2/(q_{\rm int} - g)$, so the threshold of Theorem 2 is the natural yardstick for any regular source. A limitation: the Robin model is exact only for an interface condition independent of frequency; a real star supplies a frequency-dependent one, for which Theorem 2 gives the count at each fixed frequency.

## 6 How the results were obtained

The author set the questions and scope and reviewed each stage; Anthropic's Claude, run as an agent with a Python environment and parallel sub-agents, did the literature reading, derivations, code and drafting. No claim rests on the assistant's word alone:

- *Starting points.* Published results were re-derived before use, exposing a sign misprint in Ref. [5] and the discontinuous mode of Ref. [3].
- *Proofs.* Every identity behind Lemma 1 and Theorems 1–2 was verified in exact arithmetic (SymPy), and the predicted mode counts were confirmed by a 1000-case spectral scan.
- *Review.* A literature search preceded every novelty claim; the zero mode $\phi_0$ is credited to Ref. [5].

These checks are internal; the work has not yet been reviewed by specialists.

**Reproducibility.** The symbolic verifications (exact for $\ell = 2$–10 and symbolically in $\ell$ where stated; root isolation of $\mathcal{N}$ for $\ell \leq 50$), the spectral computations and the figure script are in the accompanying repository.

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